

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Judaism as a lived religion in the United Kingdom and throughout the world.

There are two sections: Beliefs and Teachings; Practices.

Students will be expected to study Judaism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian.

Students should compare and contrast two areas of belief and practice within Christianity and Judaism:

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.8)*
- The practice and significance of worship (2.4)*.

Students should recognise that Judaism is one of the many religious traditions in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam and Sikhism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content. Students should also recognise that within Judaism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Judaism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout including reference to Orthodox, Reform and Liberal traditions.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs and practices to Jews today should be explored throughout the two sections.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of the Almighty: how the characteristics of the Almighty are shown in the Torah, and why they are important in Jewish life today, including One, Creator, Law-Giver and Judge, including reference to Genesis 2.
1.2	The nature and importance of Shekhinah: how the divine presence is shown in the Torah and why it is important, including interpretations of 2 Chronicles 7:1–3; the divergent understandings of Shekhinah found in different forms of Orthodox Judaism and the importance of them for Jews today.
1.3	The nature and purpose of the Messiah: how messiahship is shown in the scriptures, including Jeremiah 23:5–8; the nature and significance of the Messianic Age and the Jewish responsibility to bring it about; divergent understandings of the Messiah in different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism and the importance of them for Jewish people today.
1.4	The covenant with Abraham and his descendants: the nature and history of the Abrahamic covenant; the role of Abraham in the covenant, including Genesis 17; why the Promised Land covenanted to Abraham and his descendants is important for Jews today.
1.5	The Covenant at Sinai: the nature and history of the Covenant at Sinai (the Ten Commandments), including Exodus 20; the role and significance of Moses in the Covenant at Sinai; divergent understandings of how and why the Decalogue is important in Jewish life today.
1.6	Sanctity of life: why human life is holy for Jewish people; how life is shown as special. The nature and importance of Pikuach Nefesh (primacy of life): life takes precedence over everything, with reference to Talmud Yoma 83-84; divergent understandings of how and why the principle of Pikuach Nefesh is applied by Jews today.
1.7	Moral principles and the Mitzvot: the nature and importance of the Mitzvot, including reference to the Mishneh Torah of Maimonides: Sefer Madda; the importance of the relationship between keeping the Mitzvot and free will; the Mitzvot between humans and the Almighty, and between humans; divergent understandings of the importance of the Mitzvot between the Almighty and humans, and between humans, for Jewish life today.
1.8*	Jewish beliefs about life after death: divergent Jewish understandings of the nature and significance of life after death, including reference to different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism; Jewish teachings about life after death, including interpretations of Ecclesiastes 12; the nature of resurrection and judgement; why belief in life after death may be important for Jews today.

Section 2: Practices

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	The nature and purpose of Jewish public acts of worship: the nature, features and purpose of Jewish public worship, including interpretations of Psalm 116:12–19; the nature, features and importance of synagogue services for the Jewish community and the individual.
2.2	The Tenakh and the Talmud: the nature, features, purpose and significance of the Tenakh (the written law) and Talmud (the oral law) for Jews in daily life today, with reference to Perkei Avot 2; the nature and purpose of Jewish laws: food laws, kashrut, including kosher, and treifah and the separation of dairy and meat, including reference to Deuteronomy 14:3–10; the divergent implications of the Jewish food laws for Jews today.
2.3	The nature and purpose of prayer in the home and of private prayer: the nature, features and purpose of prayer three times a day; the importance of having different forms of prayers, including interpretations of Psalm 55:16–23.
2.4*	The nature and importance of the Shema and the Amidah (the standing prayer); when the Shema and the Amidah might be used, how and why, including reference to the Mezuzah; the importance of having the Shema and the Amidah for Jews today, including reference to Deuteronomy 6:4.
2.5	The importance of ritual for Jews today: the nature, features and purpose of birth rituals (including Brit Milah), Bar and Bat Mitzvahs, and marriage rituals, including interpretations of Genesis 21:1–8 and Leviticus 12; the nature, purpose and importance of the mourning rituals of funeral, shiva, avelut and yahrzeit for Jews today; divergent understandings of the importance of each ritual for different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism today.
2.6	The nature, features, history and purpose of celebrating Shabbat: the nature, features and purpose of the celebration of Shabbat in the home and in the synagogue, including interpretations of Exodus 31:12–18; why the celebration of Shabbat is important for the Jewish community and the individual today.
2.7	Jewish festivals: the nature, history, purpose and significance of Jewish festivals; the origins and meaning of specific festivals, including Rosh Hashanah, Yom Kippur, Pesach, Shavuot and Sukkot, including interpretations of Leviticus 23 (Rosh Hashanah); divergent understandings of why festivals are important to different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism today.
2.8	Features of the synagogue: the nature, history and purpose of the different design of the synagogues in Liberal, Reform and Orthodox Judaism, including facing Jerusalem, layout of seating the Ark and the bimah and with reference to Proverbs 14:28; how and why the synagogue is used by the different communities, including reference to Exodus 27:20–21; how and why objects of devotion are used within the synagogues, including a yad, Torah Scroll, ner tamid and menorah.